

The early-application *playbook.*

A practical look at Early Action, Early Decision, and Restrictive Early Action — what each one signals, where they conflict, and how to choose between *them*.

ONE / APPLICATION TYPES

Five ways to apply, five different *games*.

Before strategy, the vocabulary. Each application type carries its own deadline, its own commitment, and its own rules about where else a student can apply. Get these definitions right and the rest of the decisions get easier.

READ THE FINE PRINT Each college's policy is unique. Confirm the details on the school's own website before applying. When a policy is ambiguous, contact the admissions office directly — written confirmation is worth the email.

DECISION	DO YOU HAVE TO ATTEND IF ADMITTED?	WHERE ELSE CAN YOU APPLY?	DEADLINE
EA	No.	Anywhere.	November
REA SCEA	No.	RD, ED2, select EAs.	November
ED ED1	Yes — unless the financial aid package is unaffordable.	RD, EA, ED2 (usually).	November
ED2	Yes — unless the financial aid package is unaffordable.	RD, EA, ED1 (usually).	January
RD	No.	Anywhere.	January

REA Restrictive Early Action.

SCEA Single-Choice Early Action — another name for REA.

ED / ED1 Any Early Decision due in November is round one. Some schools call it "ED," others "ED1."

ED2 Most schools use this name for Early Decision applications due in January.

Binding versus nonbinding.

BINDING	NONBINDING
If admitted, the student is required to attend. Other applications must be withdrawn.	Admission is an offer, not a commitment. The student is free to accept or decline.

TWO / STRATEGY

Choosing the strategy that fits the *family*.

There is no single right answer — the right approach depends on how certain a student is about a top choice, how heavy the senior-year workload looks, and whether financial aid is a deciding factor. Three patterns cover most situations.

The aggressive strategy.

Reserved for students who are proactive, on top of their workload, and entirely confident about the top-choice reach and target schools.

TYPE	COLLEGE	NOTES
ED1 / REA	1st choice	If the 1st choice doesn't offer ED or REA, do not ED1 somewhere else.
ED2	Top-choice target school	Confirm this ED2 permits an ED1 application elsewhere.
EA	All other reach schools	Keep the workload manageable. Prioritize EAs that are required for the major or program.

Two alternative strategies.

- **Not sure about a top choice.** EA two or three top choices and decide between them in the spring.
- **Sure about top choice(s) but busy.** ED1 or ED2 the top choice (or top target), and RD everything else — unless EA is required for a particular school or program.

When to step back from ED.

- If a student is in the middle of an important project that extends past November, RD all schools rather than rush.
- If junior-year grades are weak, applying RD to top choices lets fall-of-senior-year transcripts do additional work.

THREE / EARLY ACTION

The gentle option — and not the strongest *bid*.

Early Action applications are typically due in early November, with decisions arriving in December. EA is nonbinding: an admitted student is free to accept or decline, and free to apply elsewhere through any channel.

Counselors disagree about whether Early Action improves admissions chances. The honest answer is that the lift is modest at best — and almost certainly smaller than the lift from Early Decision.

If Early Action helps a student's odds, it helps less than Early Decision.

What to weigh before applying EA.

- **Give the supplementals time.** A rushed EA is weaker than a polished RD. If the workload is tight, the application is better off in the regular round.
- **The first "why this college" essay is rarely the best.** Students improve with practice. Unless there is a genuine, specific reason a particular school is the first to write about, expect early drafts to be the weakest.
- **The published benefits of EA are not impressive.** Even CollegeBoard's own list of advantages is thin. EA is most useful when the application is ready and the school requires it for a scholarship or program — less so as a generic strategy.

When a school requires EA.

Some colleges require an Early Action application for the student to be considered for:

- Merit scholarships.
- Impacted (popular) majors.
- Honors programs.

Required-EA policies vary by school, by major, and from year to year. Confirm each prospective school's rules directly before finalizing the strategy.

FOUR / RESTRICTIVE / SINGLE-CHOICE EARLY ACTION

REA says *top choice* — without the binding contract.

REA and SCEA function like Early Action — nonbinding, with results around December — but with a major restriction: a student cannot file other binding (ED) or restrictive applications alongside them. They sit between EA and ED in both signal strength and commitment level.

REA and SCEA communicate a higher degree of interest than EA, with the financial flexibility ED removes.

What can be filed alongside an REA.

The REA contract is narrower than students often assume. Three carve-outs cover most of the questions families ask.

SPECIAL ACADEMIC AND HONORS PROGRAMS

Special academic programs and honors tracks that require an EA application are permitted alongside an REA. ED1s and additional REAs (any other binding application) are not.

WORKED EXAMPLE — DREXEL BA/BS+MD

Drexel's BA/BS+MD Early Assurance is a special academic program. Stanford's admissions office confirms that a student may file Stanford REA alongside Drexel BA/BS+MD. Harvard REA + Drexel BA/BS+MD is similarly permitted. Two REAs, however, are never permitted.

Note the inverse: NSU's BS/DO program allows EA, ED, or RD applications. Because NSU offers an EA option, a student applying REA to Stanford or Harvard would need to apply RD to NSU — not EA.

SCHOLARSHIP-REQUIRED EAS

An REA does not block applications to other colleges that require an EA submission for scholarship consideration. USC, for example, requires an EA application to be considered for its merit scholarship — a student may file REA to Stanford and EA to USC.

PUBLIC SCHOOLS

Nonbinding public-school applications are unaffected by an REA. The University of California's 11/30 deadline, for instance, does not conflict with any private-school REA.

FIVE / EARLY DECISION

The strongest bid — with the heaviest *strings*.

Early Decision is binding: an admitted student is required to attend, unless the financial aid package is unaffordable. It produces the largest documented bump in admissions chances of any application type — and the largest reduction in financial flexibility.

ED1 and ED2 are rounds, not parallel options.

Early Decision is split into ED1 and ED2. They are called "rounds" because they happen in order and don't interfere with each other. An ED1 decision is released before admissions officers look at the ED2 application. If the student is admitted ED1, the ED2 application — and all other applications — must be withdrawn.

If a school offers only one option called "Early Decision," it is most likely ED1.

- **ED1** (sometimes just called "ED") is usually due in early November.
- **ED2** is usually due in January.

ED1 most strongly improves admissions chances of any application type — but the student still has to be qualified to be admitted.

What ED2 actually does.

Most colleges describe ED2 as the option for students whose top choice was always clear, but who needed more time than the ED1 deadline allowed.

In reality, ED2 gives aggressive applicants a stronger bid for their top-choice target.

That is not how colleges intend ED2 to be used, but the strategic move is well-known among counselors and well-documented in admissions outcomes. Early Decision is widely criticized as predatory: it produces more stress than any other application option, and applicants cannot compare financial-aid offers across schools. (Per the New York Times, families *can* exit an ED contract if the offered aid package is unaffordable — many do not realize this.)

SPEAK WITH A COUNSELOR

Strategy is personal. *Build it deliberately.*

The right early-application plan depends on a student's certainty, workload, and finances — not a generic playbook. Admissions Partners works with each family to build a tailored strategy *before* any deadlines are committed.

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